

an Ibo Ogbugulu Mau mask, is the only definitely Ibo mask reproduced in this book and the reviewer is unable to detect in it any particular affinity with the others. One final point; on page 14 of the same book the author specifies the colours used by native artists on their masks. 'Black (soot)' is not one of them. The Ibibio, for instance, use a stain obtained from the juice of certain leaves. Of course, old carvings which have been kept for years in the roof of huts, to preserve them from boring insects, acquire a black patina from the smoke of the fires beneath them but this is quite another matter.

These are all criticisms of petty detail; the great value of these two volumes lies in their magnificent series of plates which speak for themselves and our thanks go to the author for his skill in their selection and to the publishers for producing them at a price well within the means of the average reader. It is to be hoped that their enterprise will meet the success which it deserves.

G. I. JONES

*The Use of Indigenous Authorities in Tribal Administration: Studies of the Meru in Kenya Colony.*

By H. E. LAMBERT. Communications from the School of African Studies, University of Cape Town. New Series No. 16. April, 1947. Pp. 44, 1 map, 3s. 6d.

MR. LAMBERT'S paper consists of two separate memoranda: 'Administrative use of the indigenous institutions of the Meru' and 'The constitution and personnel of statutory institutions in the Meru Native Reserve', preceded by an ethnographic introduction and followed by extracts from the Meru Annual Reports for 1939, 1940, and 1941. The people concerned are a group of Bantu tribes inhabiting the district of the same name east of Mount Kenya and speaking dialects allied to Kikuyu. The whole group, numbering about 230,000, comprises the Meru proper who are geographically subdivided into the Imenti, Tigania, and Igembe sections, and smaller related tribes in the south of the district: the Miutini, Igoji, Mwimbi, Muthambi, Tharaka, and Chuka.

Among the Meru, as among other Bantu peoples of Kenya, chiefship as an indigenous hereditary institution does not exist. Prior to the establishment of British administration, internal government was in the hands of councils of elders. An important feature of Meru polity is the age-set institution. In the specialized Meru system the whole male society is bisected into two divisions between which the sets alternate, so that each set belongs to the same division as the next but one above and the next but one below it. From initiation on the sets pass through the successive stages of the warriors, the young married men, the rulers, the old men and the aged. Since the stage of the rulers is the next but one above that of the warriors, the 'rule', or the combined administrative-judicial and executive functions, is theoretically always held by one of the two divisions for the duration of a political period, about ten or twelve years; it passes to the other division at the next handing-over ceremony, when each set advances to the next higher stage.

Actually indigenous authority is more stable than this scheme suggests. There are only two councils of the married sets, the *kiama kya nkomango*, a body with limited functions to which all married men may belong, and the *njuri ya kiama* (or *njuri ncheke*), the senior council or governing body. Just as membership of the *kiama* is not confined to the young married men, the *njuri* is not exclusively recruited from the rulers. Thus both councils, the wider and the more select, cut across the age-set system. The *njuri* is in fact the working nucleus of the *kiama*. Within each *mwiriga*, or larger localized kin-group, the *njuri* are chosen by the *kiama* from among their numbers. The *njuri* elders of a *mwiriga* will combine with those of the next *mwiriga* to settle matters affecting both groups. On the *njuri* council governing a larger tribal section the *njuri* of the various constituent *miiriga* are represented by their *agambi*, or 'speakers', that is, men of outstanding personality who are recognized as leaders within their respective narrower circles.

On questions of the composition of tribal units, of clan constitution and the relation of the clan organization to the age-set and council systems the author is not as explicit as might be desired. In native use the term *mwiriga* (pl. *miiriga*) is applied indiscriminately to kin-groups of varying scale. In the context of this paper it is used more specifically for the compact territorial groups which represent the internal administrative units. As the cohesion of such a group is largely based on a belief in descent from a common ancestor it might perhaps be described as a localized patrilineal clan, though the author avoids this term. He defines the *mwiriga*, rather negatively, as an extended clan, or as an administrative unit somewhat bigger than an exogamous clan, adding that the term can be used for the latter as well.

But Mr. Lambert's main object is not an ethnographical but a practical one, an administrator's discussion of the means by which the indigenous political institutions of the Meru can be integrated into the present system of administration. Obviously native political institutions as such, not merely individual natives as direct agents of Government, have to be brought into the administrative system if the postulate of 'indirect rule' is to be implemented. But genuine indirect rule is a difficult problem, particularly where it cannot be based on indigenous hereditary chiefship. So far the incorporation of indigenous political institutions seems to be, on the whole, more an ideal than a reality.

The first of the two memoranda is a plea for the more extensive recognition and use of the indigenous *njuri* councils as an essential part of the system of government. In the past the *njuri* were, because of their opposition to what they considered arbitrary methods of rule, often actively oppressed. Government-created chiefs chose and employed as their executive the so-called *njama*, men without tribal standing whose authority was based entirely on their being chiefs' satellites and who made their living by arbitrarily deciding cases and imposing penalties. The *njama*-system seems now to have been abolished or at least to be discouraged. But the first attempts to replace the *njama* by the *agambi* of each *mwiriga* were failures. The *agambi* were erroneously regarded as the heads of sub-clans, and expected to support an administration which continued to ignore the *njuri*. Actually the *njuri* is the real indigenous government, and a *mugambi*, who is only a *primus inter pares* in it, cannot be expected to work against his own team. Only since 1933 has an attempt been made to work together with the *njuri*, whose aid has been enlisted in such matters as, for instance, soil conservation and forest control.

In the second memorandum Mr. Lambert discusses the chances of making existing institutions more generally accepted by changes in the constitution and in the selection of personnel. Chiefs and headmen, native tribunals, the Local Native Council, and the Local Land Board are examined in this connexion. Some remarks on the author's discussion of Government-imported chiefship in a traditionally chiefless society have to suffice as a review. It seems that chiefs imposed by Government as its direct agents are an indispensable factor in the present scheme of administration. In the author's opinion Government should retain the right to appoint these men, but should, whenever possible, appoint men who have a tribal standing as *agambi* and members of the *njuri*. A chief is more likely to be successful if he is in a position of liaison between the alien and the indigenous government, by belonging to and having the support of both. If it is not possible to appoint a man who is a resident of the location to be administered by him, an anthropological investigation should discover whether or not the nominee is acceptable to the location as well as likely to be satisfactory from the point of view of Government. Lastly, the chief's status should be that of a 'Chief-in-Council', the council being formed by the leading *agambi* of both age-divisions of all clans in the chief's jurisdiction.

As an example of the necessity for anthropological inquiries in connexion with appointments, the author mentions the implications of a relationship called *gichiaro* which exists

between clans and larger tribal sections in areas more or less remote from one another. He translates the native term as 'blood-brotherhood between tribal sections larger than the family'. This collective relationship imposes on the two groups concerned juridical abstention from enmity, enforcing on each group not only submission to extortion by members of the other group but also the granting of sanctuary to criminals from the other group. It is an artificial friendship which rather precludes real friendship. If a chief should be appointed to a location with which his own tribal section has *gichiario* ties he would be unable to administer it impartially, as he could not take administrative action against his *gichiario* partners.

Incidentally, before accepting Mr. Lambert's translation of the term *gichiario* as 'section blood-brotherhood' one would like to know by what means the relationship is established. Anthropologists apply fixed conceptual categories to social phenomena; no doubt social relations or modes of behaviour covered by different categories may often actually blend into one another. It is not suggested that collective blood-brotherhood does not exist, but from Mr. Lambert's description *gichiario* looks rather like a form of 'joking relationship', more commonly known in east Africa under the Swahili term *utani*.

H. MEINHARD

*Problems of African Development. Part 1: Land and Labour.* By T. R. BATTEN. London: Oxford University Press, 1947. Pp. viii+178. 3s. 6d.

THIS book derives its interest and significance from the fact that it tries 'to assess the situation from the standpoint of educated Africans', and Mr. Batten's experience in teaching African students at Makerere College gives him special qualifications for making this attempt.

The greater part of the book—eleven chapters out of twenty—is devoted to problems of the land: systems of land tenure, the conservation of the soil, farming methods, forestry, &c. These chapters are written with admirable understanding and lucidity and give throughout the impression of first-hand knowledge supplemented by a wisely selective use of the relevant literature. They should prove highly suitable for impressing upon Africans the fundamental and urgent character of the problems and dangers which face African communities in respect of their principal asset.

Unfortunately, this high standard is not kept up in the last part of the book which deals with other departments of economic life such as labour, capital equipment, external and internal trade. Most of these topics open up wider aspects of economic and social development, and, if they had to be included, demand a much more thorough discussion. The best course, which may not have been open to the author, would probably have been to treat them in a separate volume.

Moreover, in dealing with these several subjects, the author does not display the sure judgement and clarity which distinguish the earlier chapters. Some of the opinions are expressed with a vagueness and uncertainty which will necessarily be imparted to the reader and are not in keeping with the declared objective of the book. For instance, the author is unable to make up his mind whether or not to advocate the replacement of migrant labour (the disadvantages of which he over-emphasizes) by a permanent resident labour force, or to argue clearly the pros and cons of each system. Even the manner of writing differs from that of the earlier chapters, and one cannot help feeling that the author has to some extent lost sight of the class of reader for whom his book is primarily designed.

The perfunctory manner of dealing with certain matters might cause confusion and misunderstanding in the minds of readers. Thus, in the discussion of non-African enterprise, no clear distinction is drawn between plantations, such as the sisal estates in Tanganyika and Kenya, which involve the residence of only a small number of non-Africans,